Dear Mr. Bernard J. Kurtin,

I would like to thank you personally for establishing the Bernard Kurtin scholarship. I'm honored to be able to recieve the scholarship in the 2025-2026 academic year. It makes me very happy that my many hours of work and research are recognized by this award.

I am a graduate student at the University of Illinois Chicago. I study mathematics, and I am a fourth-year Ph.D. candidate. Like you, I believe strongly in the importance of math and science. To that end, I have sought to make an impact through mathematical research. My work lies in Hodge theory, a field relevant to mathematicians and physicists alike, which aims to relate linear algebra and geometry and addess some of the many unsolved mathematical questions posed by string theory.

Most of my work is performed with pen and paper, requiring little to no funding beyond my income. However, a few practical aspects of my job demand a sizable budget. I have already produced a paper, but to more effectively communicate my results to other researchers in the math community, I am required to frequently travel to conferences and workshops. Additionally, I will be applying for post-doc positions in the Fall 2026 semester, before which I will need to travel to different universities and present my work.

To that end, the Bernard Kurtin scholarship will save me a lot of worry. I will be able to more easily afford waiting the time it takes for my travel expenses to be reimbursed; I will likewise have fewer issues finding funding for the few expenses that fall through the reimbursement process, like food and conference fees.

The scholarship has already had an impact on me. I have made plans to attend three different conferences within the next year, two of which are in Europe and would otherwise have required very careful planning. This award has made it noticably easier to make otherwise risky decisions in hopes of furthering my academic career. Once again, I thank you for establishing this scholarship, thereby enabling me to focus on doing math.

Sincerely,

Edward Varvak